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The Next Step

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The Next Step

Following wherever God leads you

God doesn't show us everything at once. He doesn't give us a map laying out everything in his plan for our lives. No, he leads us bit by bit, and we have to follow one step at a time. It can be scary. It may not be how we'd like it to go, but that's why we need to trust. His Word is the "light on my path" (Psalm 119:105).

In their hearts humans plan their course, but the Lord establishes their steps.—
Proverbs 16:9

As you do the things we've already talked about—look at your life from a biblical frame of mind, see God for who he really is and rely on the Holy Spirit—you'll be more and more equipped to follow him to the wonderful destination he has for you.

The Journey vs. the Destination

We wonder if you've ever pondered the fact that there's a difference between *God's will* and *God's plan*. They're not contradictory; they're just not the same.

To ask, "What is God's will for me?" is to ask a destination question. To ask, "What is God's will for my love life?" is to ask whether you'll ever be married. It doesn't address who you'll be married to, when you'll find that person or how the union will come about.

To ask, "What is God's plan for me?" is to ask a journey question. It covers all of the when, where, how and who issues. Even though his *will* is for you to be married, ahead of you still lies a whole process of undergoing personal change, looking for the right mate, getting to know that person and moving toward marriage together. That's his *plan*, and you don't know what it looks like yet.

God's plan requires you to trust and obey. He'll let you know his *will* for you in advance, but he'll only reveal his *plan* step by step. We're back to the flashlight illuminating one piece of the trail at a time. Take the step in front of you and don't worry about all the twists and turns that lie out of sight. God knows what he's doing.

God's Higher Thoughts

The reason we have a hard time giving up our headlong pursuit of our own plan in favor of following God's plan step by step is that our plan makes sense to us. We need to cultivate a trust in God's superior understanding. Our reasoning is natural and flawed. His reason is supernatural and perfect.

We're not trying to get you to stop reasoning for yourself; we're just trying to get you to adopt *sanctified* reasoning—reasoning that's shaped and guided by God. The Holy Spirit helps us to reason through Scripture and thus understand our own situation better. The result is that, rather than being mindless, “we have the mind of Christ” (1 Corinthians 2:16).

When we begin to take on the mind of Christ, and start accepting the fact that God knows better than we do, then it becomes easier to trust him as he escorts us along the journey to his best for us.

Trustworthy

Does God have the ability to lead us to the ideal mate for us? Sure, he does! He's Almighty God. He knows us, knows the other person and is fully capable of orchestrating events to put us together as we follow his lead.

Ah, Sovereign Lord, you have made the heavens and the earth by your great power and outstretched arm. Nothing is too hard for you. —Jeremiah 32:17

Does God have the willingness to put us together with our intended mate? Again, sure! As we saw in chapter 1, he's a loving Father who desires to give good gifts. Unless there is something unusual in his plan for our lives, marriage is a part of it.

The Lord's unfailing love surrounds the one who trusts in him. —Psalm 32:10

And finally, does God have the integrity we need to see in order of us to trust him for a spouse? Absolutely. His faithfulness is unmatched. He fulfills every promise he ever makes.

Let us hold tightly without wavering to the hope we affirm, for God can be trusted to keep his promise. —Hebrews 10:23, NLT

The Demonstration of Trust

Real trust is not lip service or mere feelings. There must be substance behind it. There must be obedience as a demonstration of our trust. We're talking about taking a step of faith. Just one. And then another, and another.

It's true that the journey ahead of you might be longer than you wish. You may go through dark valleys. There might be detours and there might be drop-offs on either side. Whatever the case may be, it's okay. If you just do the next step, you will get there. Lean on his Word and his understanding in times of seeming hopelessness, and he will provide you with the love, strength and encouragement you need to take the next step.

The above article is an abridged version of Chapter 8 of the book, *Soul Mate by God* ([Download the free ebook in PDF](#)). Visit SoulMatebyGod.com for more resources.

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In Christ,

The JesusOnline Ministries Team

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